The maple syrup helps the carrot to caramelize in the oven, giving this soup its deep, rich flavor. If you cannot find lovage, use chopped chives to finish.

maple-roasted carrot and ginger soup

SERVES 8 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 55–65 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

4½lb (2kg) carrots, cut roughly into little-finger-sized pieces
2 onions, cut into eighths
1¾in (4cm) piece of ginger, cut into matchsticks
4 garlic cloves, peeled
3 tbsp sunflower oil
4 tbsp maple syrup
1½ quarts (1½ liters) chicken or vegetable stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
a couple of squeezes of lemon juice (optional)
chopped lovage, to serve

1 Preheat the oven to 425°F (220°C). Place the carrots in a roasting pan with onion, ginger, garlic, sunflower oil, and maple syrup. Mix thoroughly with your hands, then smooth down lightly. Roast for about 45–60 minutes, turning occasionally, until the vegetables are very tender and patched here and there with brown.

2 Cool slightly, then scrape into a blender, including as much of the brown sticky residue at the bottom of the pan as you can scrape off. Add half the stock and process until smooth, adding more stock if necessary. You may need to do this in batches.

3 Pour into a saucepan and stir in the last of the stock, adding extra if necessary to thin the soup. Season with salt and pepper and taste. Add a couple of squeezes of lemon juice if you find the sweetness too intense. Heat thoroughly just before serving, and sprinkle each bowlful with chopped lovage or chives.